

COMPANION TO THE MILLENNIUM INTERVIEW GUIDE

Hedge Funds from Zero

What a hedge fund is, how it differs from every other kind of investor, and what is happening to the industry right now. Built for someone with no finance background who wants to talk about it well.

Prepared: 4 September 2026

Scope: the industry, not any single fund's trades. Millennium appears only as a worked example.

Sources: every non-obvious claim carries a marker [Sxx] resolved in Part 5. Numbering is shared with the main interview guide so the two can be read together. Claims are tagged Confirmed, Reported (single credible source, usually a press estimate) or Inferred (the author's reasoning).

How to read it: Part 1 in one sitting, then Part 2 for the news. Part 3 gives you the words to use. Part 4 is the glossary.

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Tags: **Confirmed** primary source or two credible outlets **Reported** single credible source **Inferred** author's reasoning
[S12] source marker, Part 5.

PART 1

What a hedge fund is, from zero

Start with what a fund is, then place hedge funds in the family of investors, then take the machine apart.

1.1 Start with a fund

A **fund** is a pot of money pooled from many investors and run by a professional manager. Investors put money in, the manager buys things with it (shares, bonds, currencies, buildings, loans), and investors own a slice of whatever the pot is worth. The manager charges a fee. That is all any fund is. What differs is *who* is allowed to invest, *what* the manager may buy, *how* the manager is paid, and *how quickly* investors can get their money back. Every type of investor on the "buy side" is a variation on those four dials.

KEY TERM: BUY SIDE AND SELL SIDE

The **buy side** is everyone who invests money: pension funds, asset managers, hedge funds, private equity. The **sell side** is the investment banks and brokers who sell them services: trading, research, financing, and introductions to companies [S176a]. Millennium is buy side. Goldman Sachs is sell side.

1.2 The buy-side family

The buy-side family: everyone who invests other people's money

Read left to right from "most ordinary" to "most specialised". The four dials under each box are the things that actually differ.

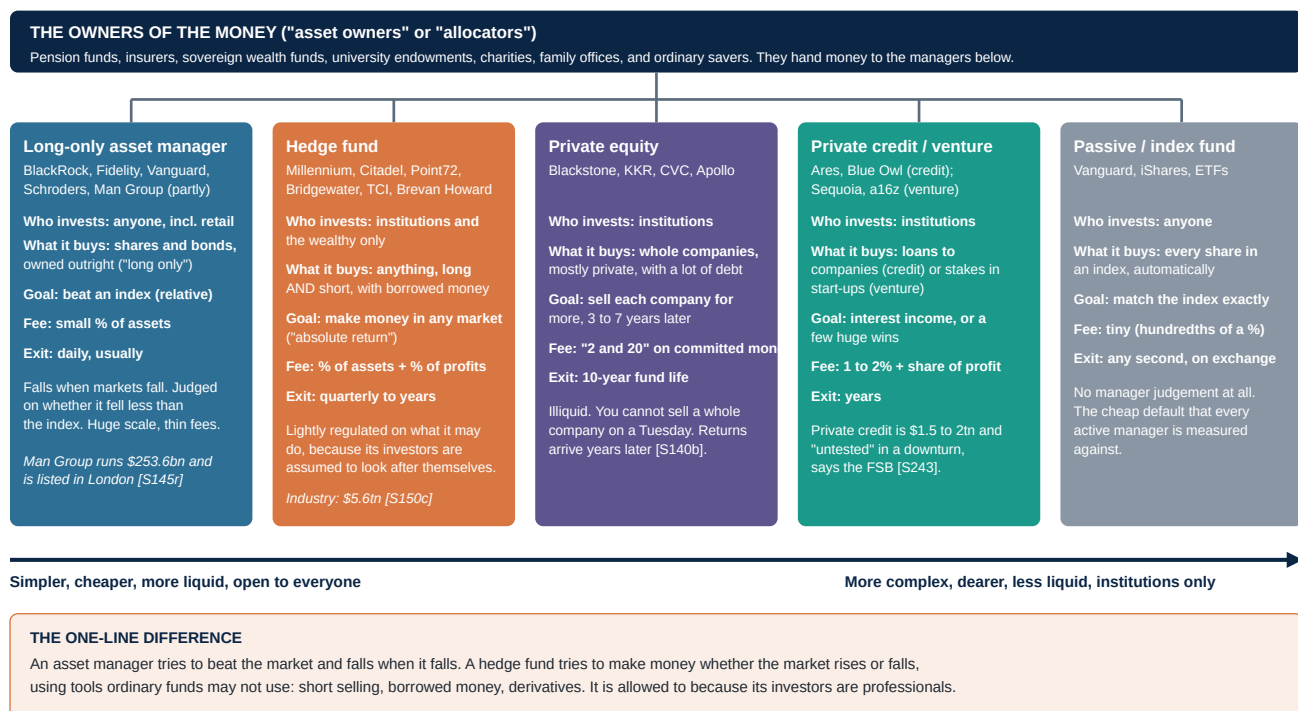


Figure 1. The buy-side family. Definitions from the SEC investor bulletin [S151], the Aurum primer [S175] and careers explainers [S140b] [S176a]; figures from HFR [S150c], Man Group results [S145r] and the FSB [S243]. Firm names are illustrative examples.

1.3 Hedge fund versus asset manager: the ten differences

People use "asset manager" to mean the big, traditional, long-only investment houses. The regulator's definition of a hedge fund shows the contrast: "Hedge funds pool investors' money and invest the money in an effort to make a positive return. Hedge funds typically have more flexible investment strategies than, for example, mutual funds. Many hedge funds seek to profit in all kinds of markets by using leverage (in other words, borrowing to increase investment exposure as well as risk), short-selling and other speculative investment practices that are not often used by mutual funds" [S151] **Confirmed** .

Ten dials: long-only asset manager versus hedge fund

Dial	Long-only asset manager	Hedge fund
1. Whose money	Anyone: retail savers, pensions, ISAs	Institutions and wealthy individuals only; "accredited" investors assumed able to bear losses [S151]
2. The goal	Relative: beat an index (the FTSE 100, the S&P 500) "Down 8% when the index fell 12%" is a good year	Absolute: positive return in any market "Up 8% when the index rose 19%" can still be the plan
3. Direction	Long only: owns things, profits if they rise	Long and short: also borrows and sells things it expects to fall, so it can profit both ways [S175]
4. Borrowed money	Little or none	Often several times its capital; market-neutral funds "may be managed with gross exposures in excess of 400%" [S175]
5. Fees	A small percentage of assets, often under 1% Index funds: hundredths of a percent	Percentage of assets plus a share of profits; average 1.32% and 15.78% in 2026 [S150d]; platforms pass costs through
6. Getting money out	Daily, usually	Monthly, quarterly or yearly, often after a lock-up of a year or more [S151]; some take five years to exit fully
7. Rules on what it may buy	Tight: diversification limits, no leverage, public disclosure	Loose on strategy, strict on conduct and on who may invest
8. Transparency	Daily prices, full holdings, public reports	Private. Investors get letters; the public gets press estimates and delayed US filings
9. Size and scale	Enormous: trillions at the biggest houses	Whole industry \$5.6tn [S150c]; largest firms \$50 to 90bn
10. How people are paid	Salary and bonus; steadier	Tied to profit; a PM keeps a share of what their book makes and can be dismissed after a small loss [S140c]

Figure 2. Ten dials. Definitions from the SEC [S151] and Aurum [S175]; fee averages from HFR [S150d]; pay from a careers explainer [S140c]. Long-only figures are generic descriptions, not sourced numbers.

SAY THIS WHEN SOMEONE ASKS "WHAT IS A HEDGE FUND?"

"A fund for professional investors that tries to make money whether markets go up or down. It can bet against things, borrow to make bets bigger, and charges a share of the profits. An ordinary fund just buys shares and hopes to beat the index."

1.4 Where the name comes from: the hedge

To **hedge** is to protect yourself against a loss. The first hedge fund, set up by Alfred Winslow Jones in 1949 [S175], bought shares it liked and simultaneously sold short shares it disliked, so that if the whole market fell, the losses on the longs were offset by gains on the shorts. What was left was the manager's skill at picking which companies would do better than which. Most hedge funds today still do some version of this.

A worked hedge: £100 long Supermarket A, £100 short Supermarket B

You think A is better run than B. You do not know whether the whole grocery sector will rise or fall. Illustrative numbers.

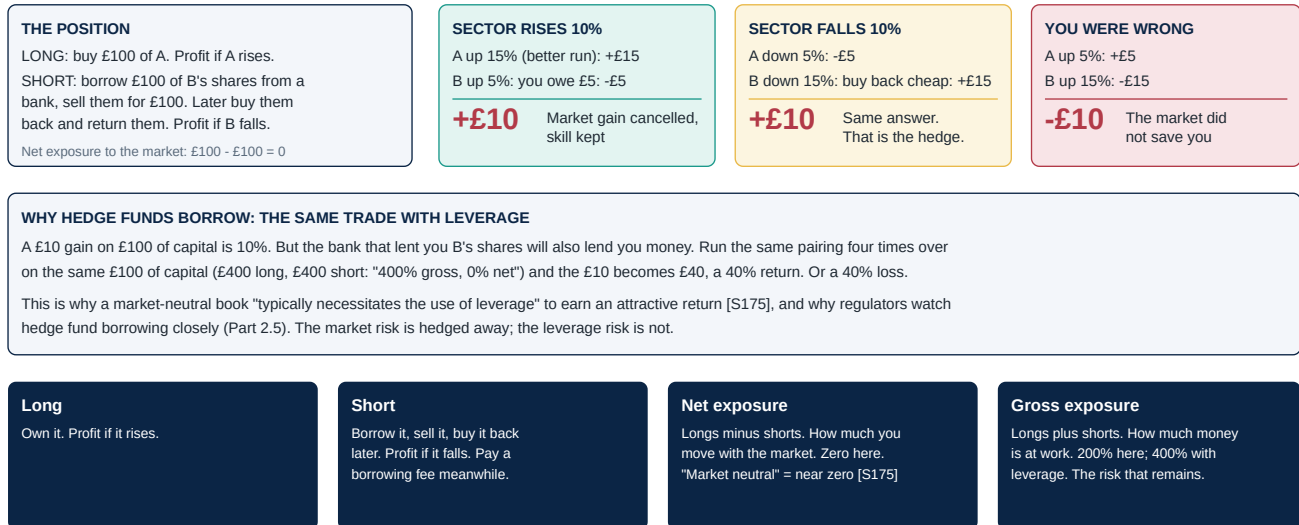


Figure 3. A worked hedge. Illustrative numbers; definitions of net and gross exposure and market neutrality from Aurum's primer [S175] and CFI [S176b].

DON'T SAY THIS

"Hedge funds are risky because they gamble on the market." The classic hedge fund takes *less* market risk than an index fund. Its risks are different: leverage, crowding (everyone in the same trade), and being wrong about which company is better. Saying that precisely is the single fastest way to sound like you understand the industry.

1.5 How a hedge fund is built

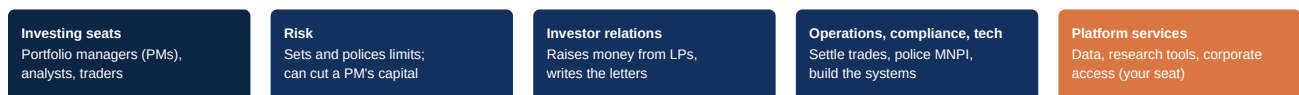
The machine: who is who around a hedge fund**THE PEOPLE THE MANAGER PAYS TO MAKE IT WORK****INSIDE THE MANAGER**

Figure 4. The machine. Roles from the SEC bulletin [S151], CFI on prime brokerage [S176c], Aurum [S175]; Millennium examples from its SEC filing [S70] and fund database [S114].

KEY TERM: LP AND GP

A hedge fund is usually a limited partnership. The investors are **limited partners (LPs)**: they supply the money and can lose only what they put in. The manager is the **general partner (GP)**: it runs the fund and takes the fees [S151]. When people say "Millennium", they usually mean the GP, the firm; the fund itself is a separate legal thing the firm manages.

1.6 The types of hedge fund

"Hedge fund" covers very different businesses. The industry data provider HFR groups the \$5.15tn of end-2025 capital into four families: equity hedge (\$1.57tn), event-driven (\$1.45tn), relative value (\$1.35tn) and macro (\$787bn) [S150a] **Confirmed**. In plain English:

The strategy map: what hedge funds actually do

Horizontal: what they bet on. Vertical: how the decision is made. Box size does not indicate assets. HFR family sizes at end-2025 in brackets [S150a].

HUMAN JUDGEMENT
Equity long/short

Buy good companies, short bad ones. The original. "Close to 20% of industry assets" [S175]. Family: equity hedge (\$1.57tn). *Biggest consumer of company meetings. Where corporate access lives.*

Event-driven

Bet on corporate events: mergers, bankruptcies, spin-offs, activism. TCI (activist, London) made a record \$18.9bn for investors in 2025 [S135]. Family: event-driven (\$1.45tn)

Global macro

Bet on countries: interest rates, currencies, bonds, commodities. Brevan Howard, Bridgewater (Pure Alpha II +34% in 2025 [S127]). Volatile years. Family: macro (\$787bn)

Credit / distressed

Buy and short bonds and loans; lend to companies others will not. Increasingly overlaps with private credit [S173a].

Relative value / arbitrage

Exploit small price gaps between related things (a bond and its future; two share classes). Tiny edges, big leverage. (\$1.35tn)

Multi-strategy / multi-manager ("pod shop")

Not a strategy but a structure: one firm runs many of the boxes on this map at once, through hundreds of independent teams under central risk limits. Millennium, Citadel, Point72, Balyasny. About \$428bn across 57 platforms, growing 16% in 2025 [S158]. Cuts across all four HFR families.

Activist

Buy a stake, then push the company to change (board, strategy, sale). A sub-type of event-driven.

Quant / systematic / statistical arbitrage

Models trade thousands of positions on data patterns. D.E. Shaw, Two Sigma, Renaissance, QRT (London, ~\$38-42bn, ~30% in 2025 [S145o]). Outperformed stock-pickers in the March 2025 shock [S163].

Trend-following / CTAs

Follow price trends in futures across markets. Do well in long moves, badly in choppy markets. In 2026 CTAs "outpaced discretionary global macro" for the first time since 2022 [S162].

Thematic / concentrated

One big idea, few positions, heavy leverage. Highest highs and the 2026 blow-up (Part 2.6) [S238].

COMPUTER-DRIVEN ("systematic", "quant")

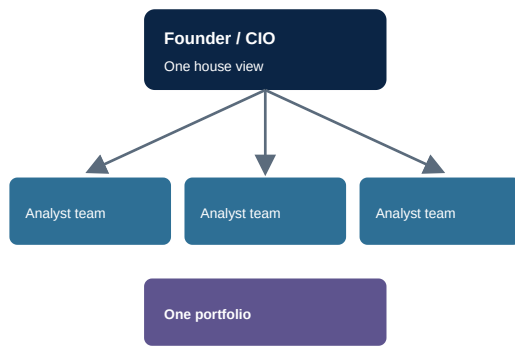
Figure 5. The strategy map. Family sizes from HFR at end-2025 [S150a]; other figures as marked. Placement on the axes is the author's simplification.

1.7 Single-manager versus multi-manager

The biggest structural split in the industry today is not strategy but organisation. A **single-manager** fund has one house view: a founder or CIO decides, analysts feed ideas up. A **multi-manager platform** has no house view: it gives capital to dozens or hundreds of independent teams, each hedged and each cut if it loses more than a set amount, and its return is the sum of many small uncorrelated bets. Aurum's description: platforms run "anywhere from a handful to over a hundred independent 'pods', each with its own portfolio manager and analysts, running tightly hedged books under a firm-wide risk framework", with the result of "far higher leverage (gross exposure of typically 400 to 600%), higher turnover levels, and lower realised portfolio volatility" [S175] **Confirmed**.

A. Single-manager hedge fund

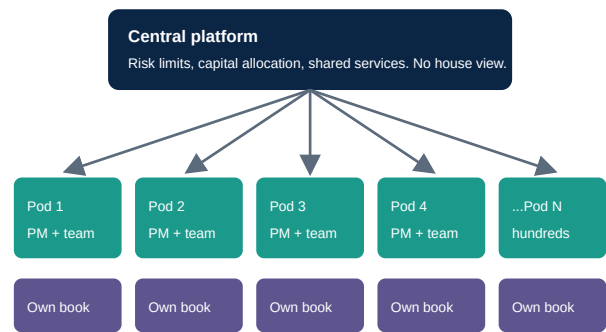
e.g. a classic "star investor" fund



- Returns depend on one person's judgement
- Concentrated bets, higher volatility
- Analysts feed ideas UP to the CIO
- Fees usually "2 and 20": 2% of assets plus 20% of profits; manager pays its own costs
- Corporate access: a few people, one client (the CIO), so brokers can serve it easily

B. Multi-manager platform ("pod shop")

Millennium, Citadel, Point72, Balyasny, ExodusPoint...



- Returns = the sum of many independent, uncorrelated bets
- Each PM has a hard loss limit; breach it and capital is cut
- Low volatility, steady returns, rarely a spectacular year
- Costs "passed through" to investors, plus a performance fee
- PMs paid only on their own pod's profit (see netting risk)
- Corporate access: hundreds of internal clients with different coverage and no obligation to engage. Needs an in-house team, a portal, and data on who used what. That is this job.

Figure 6. Single-manager versus multi-manager. Structural description from Aurum [S175]; corporate access implications inferred.

KEY TERM: PASS-THROUGH FEES

Traditional funds charge "2 and 20": 2% of assets a year plus 20% of profits, and the manager pays its own costs out of the 2%. Multi-manager platforms instead bill investors for their actual costs, mostly the pay of the trading teams, with no cap, plus a performance fee. Bloomberg's analysis of regulatory filings found these pass-through expenses "typically range from 3% to 10% of net assets" [S156] **Reported**. Investors accept it when the net return after everything is good and steady. This is the fee debate in Part 2.3.

1.8 The words you need

AUM (assets under management): the total investor money a firm runs. The standard size measure. For private firms it is a press estimate that moves monthly.

Alpha and beta. Beta is return from simply being exposed to the market. Alpha is return from skill on top. Investors "are understandably reluctant to pay high fees for beta" [S175]. Index funds sell beta cheaply; hedge funds sell alpha dearly.

Sharpe ratio. Return above cash divided by how much the return bounces around. Return per unit of risk. Above 1 is good; multi-manager platforms target 2 or more and care about this far more than raw return.

High-water mark. Performance fees are charged only on gains above the fund's previous peak, so investors never pay twice for recovering a loss [S176d].

Hurdle. A minimum return before performance fees apply. A "cash hurdle" means only returns above what cash pays are charged for. Texas Teachers' Joel Hinkhouse: "If you are a hedge fund and return 5.25%, you have not made us alpha. So, you should not take a carry for that" [S167a].

Lock-up, gate, redemption. Funds "typically limit opportunities to redeem" to monthly, quarterly or yearly and "often impose a 'lock-up' period of one year or more" [S151]. A gate caps how much can leave per period. Millennium's main share class allows 5% a quarter, so full exit takes five years [S111].

Drawdown. The fall from a peak to a trough. Platforms enforce "drawdown triggers" on each team [S175]; press reports Millennium halves a PM's capital at a 5% loss and removes them at 7.5% [S104][S113]

Reported, two outlets .

Volatility. How much returns swing. Multi-strategy funds run volatility about four times lower than world equities and a beta of about 0.24 [S172].

Netting risk. On a platform, investors pay winning teams' share of profit even in a year when losing teams drag the total down. Investors "assume the 'netting risk' of underperforming PMs" [S175].

De-grossing. Cutting both longs and shorts at once because risk limits bite. When many funds do it together, prices gap. See Part 2.6.

1.9 The ecosystem around a hedge fund

The ecosystem: who pays whom, and who watches

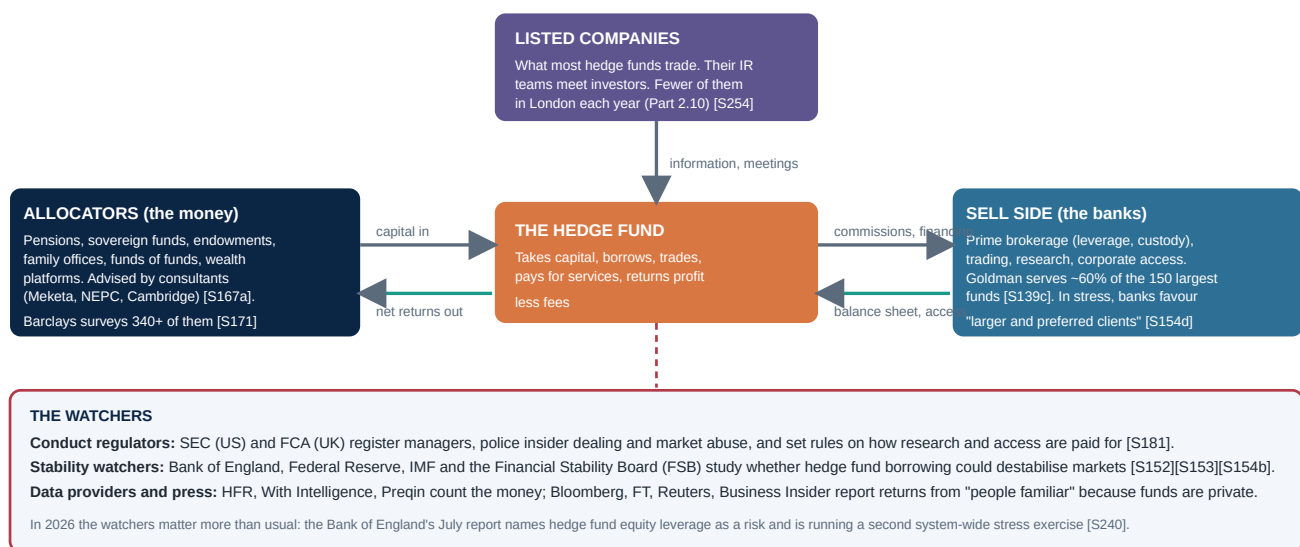


Figure 7. The ecosystem. Bank penetration from a consultancy citing OFR data [S139c]; the Bank of England stress exercise [S154d] [S240]; consultants and allocator surveys [S167a][S171].

PART 2

What is happening to hedge funds right now

Nine forces, as of 4 September 2026, drawn from industry reports (HFR, Barclays, BNP Paribas, With Intelligence, Goldman Sachs as reported), regulator publications (Bank of England, Federal Reserve, IMF, FSB) and the trade press. The short answer to "is it fundraising, trust, or war?" is: fundraising is strong but narrow; trust is contested on fees; war and shocks tested the model twice this year and it mostly held.

2.1 The dashboard

Nine forces on hedge funds, September 2026

Colour = the author's read of the direction for the industry as a whole. Green: tailwind. Amber: contested. Red: headwind or risk. Every number is dated and sourced below.



Figure 8. The 2026 dashboard. Colours are the author's judgement; every figure is sourced as marked and detailed in 2.2 to 2.10. As of 4 September 2026.

2.2 Money: fundraising is strong, and narrow

If you only remember one thing: hedge funds are not short of money in 2026. HFR's industry capital series reads \$5.15tn at the end of 2025, \$5.22tn at the end of March 2026 and a record \$5.6tn at the end of June, after a quarterly rise of about \$409bn, "the largest increase in history", and "15 consecutive quarters" of growth [S150a][S150b][S150c] **Confirmed**. HFR's president: "The current environment is unequivocally the strongest for hedge fund capital growth since industry inception" [S150c]. Reuters reports that "every major hedge fund strategy brought in fresh capital during the first half, a first in five years" [S221]. Barclays' survey of 340-plus investors found net interest at its highest since 2018, and 43% expecting to be net allocators in the second half [S171][S139b] **Reported**.

Left: global hedge fund capital (HFR, \$tn). Right: where Q1 2026 net inflows went (\$bn)

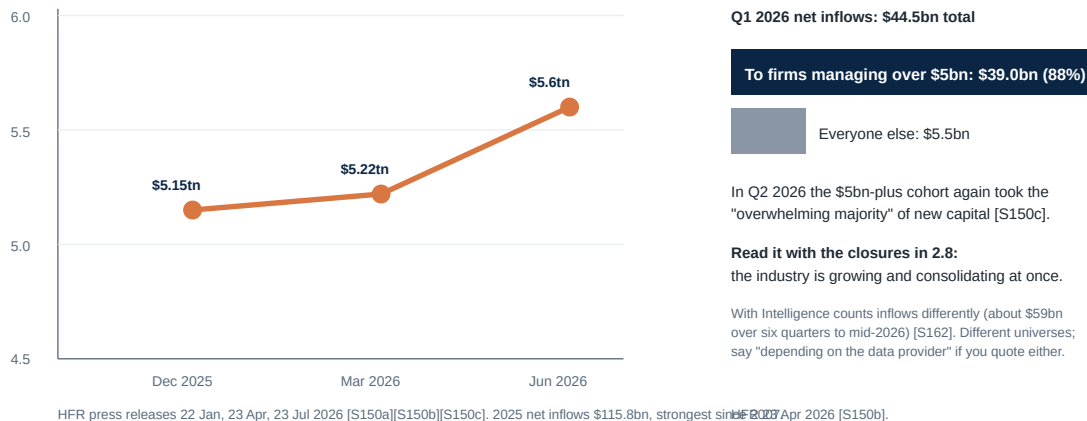


Figure 9. Industry capital and where new money goes. HFR [S150a][S150b][S150c]; With Intelligence for the alternative count [S162].

Who is giving. Family offices and private banks are "leading renewed enthusiasm" [S171]; named 2026 allocations include CalSTRS narrowing a \$4bn underweight, Virginia's retirement system deploying \$1.3bn, and North Carolina putting \$500m with Balyasny [S162]. More than one in five allocation intentions in the first half targeted multi-strategy funds [S162]. **What they want.** Low correlation to equities, net returns above cash, and increasingly separately managed accounts for transparency: about a quarter of investors now use them [S171][S172].

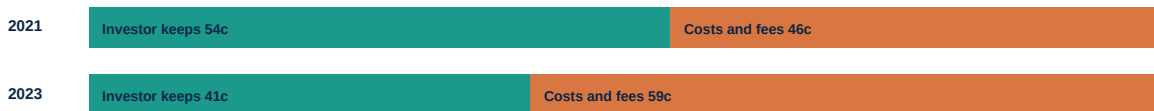
SOURCE UNCERTAIN

Inflow figures vary by an order of magnitude between providers because they count different fund universes. The direction (positive, concentrated in the largest firms) is consistent across HFR, With Intelligence and Barclays. The exact totals are not.

2.3 Trust: the fee fight

"Trust" in 2026 is mostly about money, not scandal. The issue is how much of what a fund earns reaches the investor. Multi-manager platforms pass their costs through, and those costs are large: Balyasny's main fund made 15.2% gross in 2023 and 2.8% net, after \$768m of pass-through of which 87% was pay; ExodusPoint made 11% gross with 8.4% of pass-through; Citadel's three largest funds charged \$12.5bn of pass-through between 2022 and September 2024, \$11bn of it compensation [S156]

Reported (Bloomberg analysis of SEC filings) . BNP Paribas data, as reported, suggests investors kept about 41 cents of each gross dollar at multi-strategy funds in 2023, down from 54 cents in 2021, though a second report quotes the same series differently, so use a range [S157].

Of each \$1 a multi-strategy fund earned before costs, how much did the investor keep?

BNP Paribas data via Hedgework, 22 Aug 2025 [S157]. A Feb 2025 report quotes 59c retained in 2023; treat the series as a range of roughly 40 to 60c.

One fund, one year (Balyasny Atlas Enhanced, 2023) [S156]

\$768m of pass-through costs, 87% of it employee pay

The pushback: a coalition of 60-plus asset owners led by Texas Teachers demands performance fees only above a cash hurdle; about three-quarters of its managers agreed [S167a][S157]. ExodusPoint added a Treasury-linked fee class [S166]. LCH: fees have consumed 48% of the industry's gross gains since inception [S134].

Figure 10. What investors keep. BNP Paribas via Hedgework [S157]; Bloomberg via Hedgework [S156]; Texas Teachers coalition [S167a]; LCH Investments [S134]. All press estimates; no fund publishes these figures.

The defence is simple and, so far, winning: net returns after everything have been good. HFR's average fund made 12.5% in 2025, the best year since 2009 [S150a]; multi-strategy funds run a beta to equities of about 0.24 [S172]; and capacity at the best firms is rationed, so investors queue. Texas Tech's Clinton Huff: "Everyone brings up the fees, but all I care about are net returns" [S160a]. The counter-evidence is the mid-tier: at Eisler, "the bulk of the losses stemmed from pass-through expenses, including staff compensation and operational costs charged directly to investors, rather than trading performance" [S161] **Reported**. Transparency is the other trust lever: about 25% of investors now use separately managed accounts, which let them see positions, and half of funds offer them [S171].

YOUR OPINION GOES HERE

Is pass-through fair? One view: fair while net returns beat what the investor could get elsewhere for the same volatility, and only then. The other: investors bear netting risk and fund the talent war, so hurdles are the minimum. Pick one and say what would change your mind.

2.4 Talent: the industry's biggest cost

Because platforms pay each team on its own profit and pass the bill to investors, the price of portfolio managers has become the central economic fact of the model. Reported examples: Point72 hired one PM with a package of "tens of millions" over five years after competition from Citadel, Millennium and Balyasny; Millennium hired a PM who had generated \$250m in 2024 on a "multimillion-dollar guaranteed deal"; another, hired by Millennium from Citadel, was "intercepted by Balyasny before sit-out period ended" and "Never worked a day at Millennium" [S160a] **Reported (WSJ via Hedgework)**. Steve Cohen: "We're seeing a lot of firms competing for great talent, no different than baseball" [S160a]. By 2026 "Top managers are now commanding guaranteed nine-figure payouts and multi-year contracts" [S160b], and the fights have gone to court: Schonfeld sued a PM who reversed a move for \$11m; Millennium is seeking about \$2.5m from a Hong Kong PM who abandoned an offer [S232][S233].

The response is to grow talent rather than buy it. Citadel's COO: "You can't only hire from the outside. You need to develop even more talent internally now" [S168]. Millennium took 190 interns in 2025 from about 50,000 applications and launched an investing internship for 2027 [S271][S168]. That is why structured internship programmes, including the one you applied to, exist.

2.5 Leverage: why central banks are watching

The leverage numbers regulators keep quoting

>\$18tn

Hedge funds' gross exposure to rate derivatives and government bonds in 2025, from under \$9tn in 2020

IMF GFSR, Apr 2026 [S152]

>1/3

Share of all hedge fund gross exposure held by the top 10 funds, up from 20% a decade ago

IMF GFSR, Apr 2026 [S152]

\$830bn

The US Treasury "basis trade" (buy the bond, sell the future, borrow to do it), top 50 funds hold ~90%

Fed FEDS Note, Jun 2026 [S155a]

~£100bn

Hedge fund borrowing in the UK gilt repo market, over 90% from "a small number" of funds, often at zero haircut

BoE FSR, Dec 2025 [S154a]

WHAT THEY SAY, AND WHAT THEY MIGHT DO

Bank of England, July 2026: "There has been a substantial rise in hedge fund leverage in equity markets, creating risks, including via the prime brokers which facilitate this activity." Equity prime-brokerage balances up about 40% in a year; hedge fund deleveraging "amplified" gilt moves after the Iran strikes [S240][S241].

Federal Reserve, June 2026: "the combination of large scale, high concentration, and elevated leverage creates the potential for systemic stress" [S155a].

FSB, July 2025: toolkit of minimum haircuts, central clearing and concentration add-ons, but "Entity-level leverage measures are less common for entities with multiple, complex strategies, such as hedge funds" [S153]. **BoE discussion paper:** minimum margins on gilt repo [S154c].

Plain-English read: no one is proposing to cap hedge fund leverage directly. The squeeze comes through the banks that lend to them, which favours the biggest, best-connected funds.

Figure 11. Leverage numbers. IMF [S152]; Federal Reserve [S155a]; Bank of England [S154a][S154b][S154c][S240][S241]; FSB [S153]. All primary regulator documents.

KEY TERM: REPO AND HAIRCUT

A **repo** (repurchase agreement) is selling a bond and agreeing to buy it back later at a slightly higher price: economically a secured loan with the bond as collateral. The **haircut** is the safety cushion the lender demands. The BoE and FSB both note hedge fund repo is often done at "zero or near-zero" haircuts [S153][S154a], which is why a proposal for minimum haircuts is a real constraint.

2.6 War and shocks: the two stress tests of 2026

2026 so far: what hit the industry and when

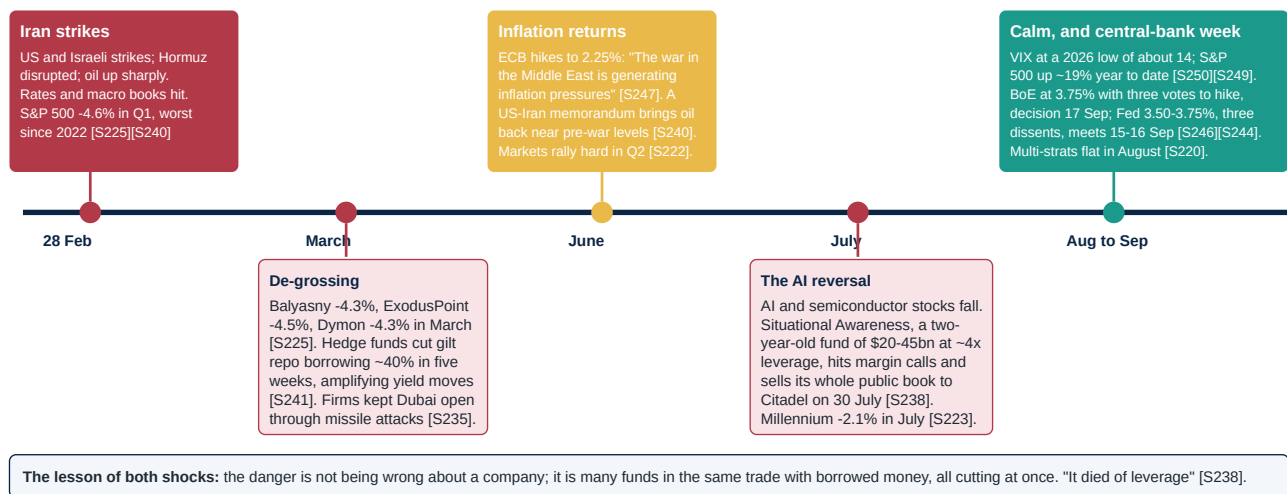


Figure 12. 2026 shock timeline. Sources as marked: Hedgeweek round-ups [S225][S223][S220], Bank of England [S240][S241], ECB [S247], Fed and BoE decisions [S244][S246], FinanceFeeds compilation [S238], data vendors [S249][S250]. The Situational Awareness figures are a secondary compilation with wide ranges.

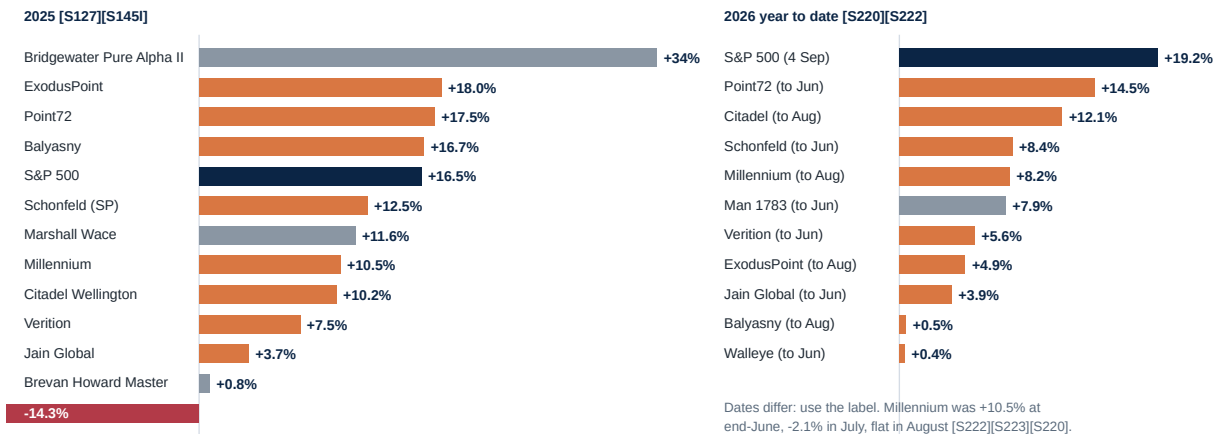
KEY TERM: CROWDING

Many funds holding the same positions. Harmless until a shock, when everyone tries to sell the same thing to the same buyers at once. The IMF says financial stress "has become more correlated with hedge fund losses since 2020" [S152]. Crowding is why platforms value information their rivals do not have, which is one reason in-house corporate access desks exist.

2.7 Performance: who won and who lost

Reported returns: 2025 full year (left) and 2026 to end-August or end-June (right)

All figures are press estimates from unnamed sources; firms declined comment. Bars in orange are multi-manager platforms; grey are other types; navy is the S&P 500.



Sources: Bloomberg via Fortune, 2 Jan 2026 [S127]; Hedgeweek on Brevan Howard [S145] and Eisler [S161]; Business Insider via Yahoo, 1 Jul 2026 [S222]; Hedgeweek 4 Sep 2026 [S220]; Trading Economics [S249].

Figure 13. Who won and lost. Every bar is a press estimate; dates as labelled. Sources [S127][S145][S161][S222][S220][S249].

Three readings of this chart, all defensible. First: 2025 was excellent for almost everyone and the industry's best year since 2009 [S150a]. Second: in 2026 the big platforms are doing what they promise, positive returns with a fraction of the market's swings, in a year when the market itself is the winner; "Most of the funds remain behind the US equity market this year" [S220]. Third: dispersion is enormous. Point72 at +14.5% and Balyasny at +0.5% are the same business model. Which teams you have, and how much crowded AI exposure they carried into July, decided the year.

2.8 The shake-out: the middle disappears

The model is not dying; the number of firms that can afford it is shrinking. Multi-manager AUM hit a record \$428bn across 57 platforms, up 16% in 2025 after a pause in 2023 and 2024 [S158]

Reported (Goldman Sachs data via secondary sources). At the same time Eisler wound down after -14.3% [S161]; Atlantic Wolf (\$3bn), Taproot, Eminence (\$8bn) and AB Arya closed in 2026 [S162]; liquidations jumped to 129 in the first quarter [S150d]. Even a record launch struggled: Jain Global raised \$5.3bn in 2024, made about \$1.8bn of gross trading profit but only 3.7% net in 2025, and in April 2026 agreed to return about \$6bn of outside money and run Millennium's capital alone [S143][S229] **Reported**. The top two took opposite paths to the same capacity problem: Citadel returned about \$5bn of 2025 profits and shrank to about \$67bn [S165]; Millennium is raising a record ~\$20bn while already at about \$92bn [S221]. LCH Investments' Rick Sopher on the top firms: they "have periodically either closed to new subscriptions or returned capital, recognising that carefully controlling asset growth is a good basis for generating significant gains" [S134].

2.9 Technology and AI

Barclays finds 55% of investors have put AI into their investment process and 75% into non-investment workflows; discretionary managers are "embedding quantitative tools to expand coverage capacity without proportional headcount" [S171]. Quant multi-strategy is the most wanted strategy among allocators [S139b]. Systematic funds have handled shocks better: up 4% in March 2025 while stock-pickers lost 2.4% [S163]; trend-followers "outpaced discretionary global macro" in 2026 for the first time since 2022 [S162]. Millennium announced an AI lab in June and an Anthropic co-development of a "digital risk analyst" in August, with its CIO stressing "keeping human judgment at the center" [S99][S117]. The friction: 69% of large managers say broker data licensing blocks AI use [S209].

2.10 Geography: London and the Gulf

London is Europe's hedge fund capital and Millennium's largest office outside the US, with a co-head of global equities relocated there and a senior equities recruiter hired from Schonfeld in May 2026 [S231]. Two pressures work against it. First, tax: "a \$20m buyout is tax-free in Dubai" against roughly \$9m of UK tax, per an eFinancialCareers analysis, and one manager says "This is why the UK government is talking about imposing an exit tax" [S236] **Reported, anonymous**. Brevan Howard's Abu Dhabi office grew from 5 people in 2023 to 150 by late 2025 [S145m]; funds kept Gulf offices open through March's missile attacks [S235]. Second, the shrinking listed market: 23 London IPOs in 2025 and 7 in the first half of 2026, recovering from a near-dead 2024 but small, while CRH, Smurfit Westrock and Flutter all moved to New York-only listings in 2026 [S254][S255]. Fewer listed companies means fewer things for equity hedge funds to trade in London and scarcer meetings with their management.

PART 3

How to talk about it

Three lengths of explanation, ten lines you can use, five traps, and the opinions worth forming.

Three ways to explain a hedge fund, by how long you have

30 SECONDS (a friend at dinner)

"A hedge fund is an investment fund for big institutions, like pension funds, that tries to make money whether markets go up or down. It can bet against companies as well as for them, and it borrows to make its bets bigger. The manager keeps a share of the profits. Millennium is one of the largest: about \$92bn, run through hundreds of small independent trading teams."

60 SECONDS (a recruiter)

"The difference from an ordinary fund is the goal. An asset manager tries to beat an index and falls when the market falls. A hedge fund targets an absolute return: it hedges out the market by owning some things and shorting others, then adds leverage to make the remaining edge worth having. Investors are institutions who accept less liquidity and higher fees for returns that don't move with equities. The industry is a record \$5.6tn and the money is concentrating in a handful of multi-manager platforms, Millennium, Citadel, Point72, that run hundreds of teams under strict loss limits. The live debates are fees, because platforms pass their costs to investors, and leverage, because central banks are watching how much these funds borrow."

3 MINUTES (an interviewer): add these four layers

- 1. Structure.** LPs, GP, prime broker, administrator. Single-manager versus multi-manager. Pass-through fees and netting risk.
- 2. Numbers.** \$5.6tn industry; \$428bn across 57 platforms; 2025 the best year since 2009 at +12.5%; investors keep 40 to 60c per gross dollar at platforms.
- 3. This year.** Iran shock and March de-grossing; July AI reversal and a \$20bn+ fund forced to sell; platforms up 0.5 to 14.5% against an S&P 500 up ~19%; record fundraising for the biggest, closures for the middle; BoE and Fed naming leverage as a risk.
- 4. A view.** "The model has not peaked, but the number of firms that can afford it has. The constraint on the winners will come through prime-broker balance sheets and repo haircuts rather than a leverage cap, and through allocators demanding cash hurdles. Both favour the largest platforms."

Then name the thing that would change your mind: a year in which the top platforms return less than cash after fees.

Figure 14. Three lengths of explanation. Figures as sourced in Parts 1 and 2 [S150a][S150c][S158][S157][S220][S225][S238][S240].

3.1 Ten lines you can use

1. "The classic hedge fund takes less market risk than an index fund. Its risks are leverage and crowding, not the market."
2. "Absolute return versus relative return is the real difference. Everything else follows from it."
3. "Hedge funds are lightly regulated on what they may buy and heavily regulated on conduct, because their investors are professionals."
4. "The industry is at a record \$5.6tn, and almost all the new money is going to firms over \$5bn."
5. "Multi-manager platforms are about 8% of hedge fund assets but a far bigger share of market activity, because they run four to six times leverage."
6. "Pass-through means investors pay the fund's actual costs. That is fine while net returns are good, which is why the fee fight is really an argument about performance."
7. "2026 had two stress tests: the Iran shock in March and the AI reversal in July. Both were leverage-and-crowding events, and the big platforms mostly absorbed them."
8. "Citadel gave money back and Millennium is raising a record amount. Two answers to the same capacity problem."
9. "Regulators are not proposing to cap hedge fund leverage. They are squeezing it through the banks that lend to hedge funds, which favours the biggest funds."
10. "Eisler is the cautionary tale: a \$3 to 4bn platform whose losses came from costs, not trades."

3.2 Five traps

- **Quoting a private firm's numbers as fact.** Say "press estimates" or "its own website says". Millennium's AUM moved from about \$70bn to \$92bn in under two years across different sources.
- **"Hedge funds beat the market."** They do not aim to. In 2026 almost none did. Explain what they do aim for.
- **"MiFID II banned bundled research."** It required separate payment; the UK and EU have since partly reversed that. If you raise regulation, get the dates right (Part 5 of the main guide).
- **Treating all hedge funds as one thing.** Bridgewater (+34% in 2025) and Brevan Howard (+0.8%) are both macro funds. Name the type.
- **Using "edge" carelessly.** Near a listed company, "edge" sounds like inside information. Say "differentiated view" or "better analysis".

3.3 Opinions worth forming

YOUR OPINION GOES HERE

Has the multi-manager model peaked? For: outflows in 2024, investors keeping 41c, closures. Against: record AUM, +16% growth, top firms oversubscribed. A defensible middle: "peaked for the mid-tier, not the top." **Is the industry good for markets?** For: liquidity, price discovery, absorbing Treasury issuance (Cayman funds bought 37% of net issuance since 2022 [S155b]). Against: crowded, leveraged unwinds amplify shocks, as the BoE found [S154b]. **Should London worry?** For: tax, listings, Gulf competition. Against: Millennium and others are building out London equities now. Pick sides, and say what evidence would move you.

PART 4

Glossary

Every term used above, in plain English.

Absolute return

Aiming for a positive return regardless of what markets do. The hedge fund goal.

Accredited investor

Someone with enough income or assets to be allowed into a hedge fund. The law assumes they can bear losses.

Activist

A fund that buys a stake then pushes the company to change.

Allocator

An institution deciding where to invest large pools: pension fund, endowment, sovereign fund. Hedge funds' customers.

Alpha

Return from skill, above what the market gave you.

AUM

Assets under management. The investor money a firm runs.

Basis trade

Buying a government bond and selling its future, with borrowed money, to capture a tiny price gap. Huge in size, watched by the Fed.

Beta

Return from simply being exposed to the market.

Buy side

Firms that invest money. Sell side: firms that sell them services.

Cash hurdle

Performance fees charged only on returns above what cash pays.

CTA / trend follower

A computer-driven fund that follows price trends in futures.

Crowding

Many funds in the same trade. Dangerous in a shock.

De-grossing

Cutting longs and shorts together to reduce risk, usually under pressure.

Drawdown

The fall from a peak to a trough in value.

Event-driven

Leverage

Borrowing, or derivatives, to hold more than your capital. Amplifies gains and losses.

Lock-up

A period during which investors cannot withdraw.

Long / short

Own it and profit if it rises / borrow and sell it and profit if it falls.

Long-only

A manager that only buys. Most traditional asset managers.

Macro

Betting on countries: rates, currencies, bonds, commodities.

Market neutral

Net exposure near zero, so the market's moves roughly cancel out.

Multi-manager / multi-strategy / pod shop / platform

One firm running many independent teams under central risk limits.

Net exposure

Longs minus shorts. How much you move with the market.

Netting risk

Investors pay winning teams even when losing teams drag the total down.

Pass-through

Investors pay the fund's actual operating costs plus a performance fee, instead of a fixed management fee.

Performance fee / carry

The manager's share of profits, often 20%.

PM

Portfolio manager. Runs a book, paid on its profit.

Pod

A PM plus analysts, running an independent book inside a platform.

Prime broker

A bank that lends a fund cash and securities, holds its assets and clears its trades. The source of leverage.

Quant / systematic

Betting on corporate events: mergers, bankruptcies, spin-offs.

Feeder and master fund

Investors put money into a feeder (often in the Cayman Islands), which invests in a master fund that holds the positions.

FSB

Financial Stability Board, the international body coordinating regulators on systemic risk.

Gate

A cap on how much money can leave a fund per period.

GP / LP

General partner (the manager) and limited partners (the investors).

Gross exposure

Longs plus shorts. How much money is at work. A measure of leverage.

Haircut

The safety cushion a lender demands against collateral in a repo.

Hedge

A position taken to offset a risk. Short B to hedge long A.

High-water mark

Performance fees only on gains above the previous peak.

Trading decided by models and data rather than human judgement.

Relative return

Aiming to beat an index. The asset-manager goal.

Relative value / arbitrage

Exploiting small price gaps between related instruments, usually with leverage.

Repo

Selling a bond and agreeing to buy it back: a secured loan.

Sharpe ratio

Return above cash per unit of volatility. Return per unit of risk.

SMA

Separately managed account: an investor's own account run by the manager, giving full sight of positions.

2 and 20

2% of assets plus 20% of profits. The classic fee; averages are now lower.

Volatility

How much returns swing. Lower is calmer.

PART 5

Sources

Every [Sxx] marker above resolves here. IDs are shared with the main interview guide. All sources accessed 4 September 2026. "Fetched" means the full text was read; "Snippet" means only a search excerpt was seen; "Paywalled" means the headline was recorded and nothing was inferred from unread text.

ID	Outlet	Title	Date	URL	Status	Confidence
[S12]	ICR	Evolving Strategies for Corporate Access: Your 2025 Playbook (Christopher Melito)	2024-12-18	https://icrinc.com/news-resources/strategies-for-corporate-access-2025/	Fetched	Reported
[S70]	SEC / IAPD	Form ADV, Millennium Management LLC, CRD 158117, Other-Than-Annual Amendment	filed 25 Aug 2026	https://adviserinfo.sec.gov/firm/summary/158117	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S99]	Hedgeweek	Millennium builds AI lab as hedge fund steps up technology drive; Millennium gets its AI Mann	29 Jun 2026; 11 Oct 2023	https://www.hedgeweek.com/millennium-builds-ai-lab-as-hedge-fund-steps-up-technology-drive... https://www.hedgeweek.com/millennium-gets-its-ai-mann/	Fetched	Reported
[S104]	Net Interest (Marc Rubinstein)	Peak Pod	15 Sep 2023	https://www.netinterest.co/p/peak-pod	Fetched	Reported
[S111]	Wall Street Journal (Juliet Chung), PDF copy hosted by Duke University	Stalwart Hedge Funds to Test Clients With New Terms	31 Oct 2018	https://public.econ.duke.edu/~boller/Econ.471-571.F18/Hedge_Fund_Terms_WSJ_103118.pdf	Fetched	Reported
[S113]	Business Insider via AOL	The strategy a \$69 billion hedge fund uses to make sure it never loses money in the stock market	2 Oct 2024	https://www.aol.com/strategy-69-billion-hedge-fund-193733084.html	Fetched	Reported
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[S117]	Millennium (mlp.com) press release	Millennium and Anthropic to Co-Develop AI-Powered Digital Risk Analyst	Aug 2026	https://www.mlp.com/millennium-and-anthropic-to-co-develop-ai-powered-digital-risk-analyst...	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed

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[S139c]	Bayes Group	The Funding Stack Problem: prime broker concentration and multi-strategy due diligence	15 Apr 2026	https://www.bayes-group.com/insights/prime-broker-concentration-multi-strategy-due-diligence	Fetches	Reported
[S140b]	Mergers & Inquisitions	Hedge Funds vs Private Equity	updated 2019+	https://mergersandinquisitions.com/hedge-fund-vs-private-equity/	Fetches	Reported
[S140c]	hedgefundinterview.com	Multi-Manager Hedge Funds: How the Pod Model Works	30 May 2026	https://hedgefundinterview.com/multi-manager-hedge-funds	Fetches	Reported
[S143]	Business Insider via Yahoo Finance (Saacks & Morrell)	Jain Global to return billions to investors in a surprise deal with Millennium	27 Apr 2026	https://finance.yahoo.com/markets/stocks/articles/jain-global-striking-deal-return-1445084...	Fetches	Reported
[S145l]	Disruption Banking	How Brevan Howard Fell Behind in the Macro Surge of 2025	30 Jan 2026	https://www.disruptionbanking.com/2026/01/30/how-brevan-howard-fell-behind-in-the-macro-surge-...	Fetches	Reported
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[S145o]	Disruption Banking	From \$23B to \$38B AUM + 30% Returns: QRT's 2025 Quant Takeover	7 Feb 2026	https://www.disruptionbanking.com/2026/02/07/from-23b-to-38b-aum-30-returns-qrts-2025-quant-takeover-...	Fetches	Reported
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[S152]	IMF	Global Financial Stability Report, April 2026, Chapter 1 (local imf.txt)	Apr 2026	https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/GFSR	Fetchd	Primary/Confirmed
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[S154a]	Bank of England	Financial Stability Report – December 2025	Dec 2025	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/financial-stability-report/2025/december-2025	Fetchd	Primary/Confirmed
[S154b]	Bank of England	Financial Stability Report – July 2026	7 Jul 2026	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/financial-stability-report/2026/july-2026	Fetchd	Primary/Confirmed
[S154c]	Bank of England	Discussion paper: Enhancing the resilience of the gilt repo market	4 Sep 2025	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/paper/2025/discussion-paper/enhancing-the-resilience-of-th...	Fetchd	Primary/Confirmed
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[S155b]	Federal Reserve Board (FEDS Notes)	The Cross-Border Trail of the Treasury Basis Trade	15 Oct 2025	https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/the-cross-border-trail-of-the-trea...	Fetches	Primary/Confirmed
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[S160a]	Hedgeweek (reporting WSJ)	Multi-manager hedge funds escalate talent war 'arms race' with nine-figure pay packages	17 Jun 2025	https://www.hedgeweek.com/multi-manager-hedge-funds-escalate-talent-war-arms-race-with-nine-figure-pay-packages	Fetches	Snippet/Paywalled
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[S162]	With Intelligence	Hedge Fund Trends 2026: Demand Strengthens as Capital Returns	1 Sep 2026	https://www.withintelligence.com/insights/hedge-fund-trends-2026/	Fetches	Reported
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[S166]	Hedgeweek (reporting Business Insider)	ExodusPoint adopts cash hurdle	12 Sep 2024	https://www.hedgeweek.com/exoduspoint-adopts-cash-hurdle/	Fetches	Reported
[S167a]	Hedgeweek	Texas Teachers gains allies in push for hedge fund fee reform	25 Jul 2024	https://www.hedgeweek.com/texas-teachers-gains-allies-in-push-for-hedge-fund-fee-reform/	Fetches	Reported

[S168]	Business Insider via AOL	How hedge funds became a bright spot in a nasty job market	24 Feb 2026	https://www.aol.com/articles/hedge-funds-became-bright-spot-090701777.html	Fetches	Reported
[S171]	Barclays Investment Bank	2026 Hedge Fund Outlook	5 Feb 2026	https://www.ib.barclays/our-insights/3-point-perspective/hedge-fund-outlook-2026.html	Fetches	Reported
[S172]	SS&C Advent (citing BNP Paribas 2026 outlook, Goldman Sachs)	Multi-Manager Funds Hit Their Stride as Allocators Double Down	17 Apr 2026	https://www.advent.com/news-and-insights/blog/multi-manager-funds-hit-their-stride-as-allo...	Fetches	Reported
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[S176b]	Corporate Finance Institute	Net Exposure	undated	https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/wealth-management/net-exposure/	Fetches	Reported
[S176c]	Corporate Finance Institute	Prime Brokerage	undated	https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/wealth-management/prime-brokerage/	Fetches	Reported
[S176d]	Corporate Finance Institute	High-Water Mark	undated	https://corporatefinanceinstitute.com/resources/wealth-management/high-water-mark/	Fetches	Reported
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[S228]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Jain Global to return external capital and shift to exclusive Millennium mandate	2026-04-27	https://www.hedgeweek.com/jain-global-to-return-external-capital-and-shift-to-exclusive-millennium-mandate/	Fetchd	Reported
[S229]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Jain Global made \$1.8bn before switching to Millennium capital	2026-09-02	https://www.hedgeweek.com/jain-global-made-1-8bn-before-switching-to-millennium-capital/	Fetchd	Reported
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[S232]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Schonfeld sues Millennium PM over alleged \$11m 'gazumping' breach	2026-04-23	https://www.hedgeweek.com/schonfeld-sues-millennium-pm-over-alleged-11m-gazumping-breach/	Fetchd	Reported
[S233]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Millennium seeks \$2.5m from Dymon PM over abandoned move	2026-08-28	https://www.hedgeweek.com/millennium-seeks-2-5m-from-dymon-pm-over-abandoned-move/	Fetchd	Reported
[S234]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Hedge fund hiring wars escalate as "interception trades" drive record pay packages	2026-04-20	https://www.hedgeweek.com/hedge-fund-hiring-wars-escalate-as-interception-trades-drive-record-pay-packages/	Fetchd	Reported
[S235]	Hedgeweek (citing Bloomberg)	Hedge funds back Dubai and Abu Dhabi despite regional conflict	2026-03-26	https://www.hedgeweek.com/hedge-funds-back-dubai-and-abu-dhabi-despite-regional-conflict/	Fetchd	Reported
[S236]	eFinancialCareers (Sarah Butcher)	The ultimate post-bonus trade is still leaving for a hedge fund in the UAE	2026-02-20	https://www.efinancialcareers.com/news/the-ultimate-post-bonus-trade-is-still-leaving-for-a-hedge-fund-in-the-uae/	Fetchd	Reported

				bonus-trade-is-still-leaving-for-...		
[S238]	FinanceFeeds (compiling CNBC, FT, Bloomberg, SpotGamma)	Leopold Aschenbrenner: \$225M to \$20B to a 6-day margin call	2026-07-31 (upd. 08-04)	https://financefeeds.com/leopold-aschenbrenner-225m-to-20-billion-6-day-margin-call-citade...	Fetched	Reported
[S240]	Bank of England	Financial Stability Report – July 2026	2026-07-07	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/financial-stability-report/2026/july-2026	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S241]	Bank of England (Andrew Bailey)	Financial Stability Report press conference opening remarks, 7 July 2026	2026-07-07	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/-/media/boe/files/financial-stability-report/2026/opening-...	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S243]	Financial Stability Board	Report on Vulnerabilities in Private Credit	2026-05-06	https://www.fsb.org/uploads/P060526.pdf	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S244]	Federal Reserve	FOMC statement	2026-07-29	https://www.federalreserve.gov/newsevents/pressreleases/monetary20260729a.htm	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S246]	Bank of England	Monetary Policy Summary and minutes, July 2026	2026-07-30	https://www.bankofengland.co.uk/monetary-policy-summary-and-minutes/2026/july-2026	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S247]	European Central Bank	Monetary policy decisions, 11 June 2026	2026-06-11	https://www.ecb.europa.eu/press/pr/date/2026/html/ecb.mp260611~4d41bd5e83.en.html	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S249]	Trading Economics	United States Stock Market (S&P 500)	2026-09-04	https://tradingeconomics.com/united-states/stock-market	Fetched	Reported
[S250]	Yahoo Finance (Chart of the Day)	Wall Street's summer calm is colliding with the year's most volatile stretch	2026-08-30	https://finance.yahoo.com/markets/article/wall-streets-summer-calm-is-colliding-with-the-y...	Fetched	Reported
[S254]	EY UK	UK IPO market recovery gains momentum in 2026 (IPO Eye H1 2026)	2026-07-08	https://www.ey.com/en_uk/newsroom/2026/07/uk-ipo-market-recovery-2026	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S255]	EY UK	London IPO market rebounds in Q4 2025 (IPO Eye Q4 2025)	2026-01-06	https://www.ey.com/en_uk/newsroom/2026/01/ipo-eye-q4-2025-london-stock-exchange	Fetched	Primary/Confirmed
[S271]	eFinancialCareers (Sarah Butcher)	Hedge fund Millennium is welcoming 190 interns this summer	2025-04-23	https://www.efinancialcareers.com/news/millennium-internships-hedge-fund	Fetched	Reported